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Phoebe Jacobs and Jackie Harris

Phoebe Jacobs has been a great friend of jazz and some of its most illustrious artists. She worked as a publicist for Duke Ellington, Ella Fitzgerald, Peggy Lee, and Louis Armstrong, and is currently the Executive Vice President of the Louis Armstrong Educational Foundation.

Jackie Harris is the Founder and Executive Director of the Louis Armstrong Summer Jazz Camp. She is well known for her marketing and production work and has played an integral role in keeping the tradition of New Orleans alive.

Phoebe and Jackie were interviewed in Rome, New York on August 21, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're in Rome, New York filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. And I'm really pleased to have two great friends and patrons of jazz with me, Phoebe Jacobs and Jackie Harris. Welcome.

PJ: Thank you very much. We're delighted to be here.

JH: It's a pleasure.

MR: Phoebe, I just have this curiosity about how did you become such an unbelievable supporter and lover of jazz music?

PJ: Well I guess like anything else I just took to the music. And my uncle owned a nightclub and I had an opportunity to work there from time to time because he'd employ all my favorite people like Louis Armstrong and Duke Ellington and Ella Fitzgerald and Count Basie and so forth, so I got involved. And I became so enamored of their artistry and I became so affected by what they had to go through to succeed. Because we are living in such a racial situation that's so terrible, yet I could recognize that they were great Americans. Because when people would call me for monies, they wanted to build a hospital, we wanted to raise money for war bonds, we needed to get a celebrity to go and help us sell tickets for whatever, my artists were the ones that went out and they never got any money for it. Louis would go play in the rain if he was selling war bonds. Duke would go and play for the USO. These were great Americans that were passionately involved with their country and their country treated them very shabbily. So I guess I decided by myself that I was going to do everything I can to make certain that they were appreciated and held in the esteem that they justifiably earned. Because I know what happened to them in Europe. I know how they were acclaimed in Europe.

MR: Did you have education or training for some of the things that you ended up doing, being a publicist and a promoter and all those kinds of things, or did you learn on the job?

PJ: My uncle was a very, very clever man and very, very good. And he gave me a lot of freedom. You know he just let me do it. And I guess I just did it. But of course I did have an education, I majored in English, I primarily wanted to be a journalist or a librarian, and as far as publicity went I just kind of instinctively knew that you had to get a message to people and I thought about the best way to do it. And I've made some mistakes but generally speaking I think I was very successful because the people that I worked with trusted me. I couldn't fail them.

MR: Jackie, would you feel the same way about what — you are in a similar business. What prepares you to put on festivals and raise money for things. How do you get that preparation?

JH: Well let me say this. You know it's just recent that an individual that's interested in doing this kind of work can go to school to learn it. It's been a profession that you've learned on the job. Now I had my training is in business. I had worked for an oil company. I had also worked in food service. And my first job in this industry was with the New Orleans Jazz & Heritage Festival and what I brought in business to the festival they allowed me to learn in the music industry. And it's been, you know, a great career. I can't imagine doing anything else with any other group of individuals. I mean I've just made a decision that this is what God put me on earth to do.

MR: When you started doing the Jazz & Heritage work was there a directive or a sense of what part of our heritage are we trying to cover here? Because there's so much in New Orleans. Did you have to balance new with old?

JH: Well but you know that's what New Orleans music is all about. You know it's about preserving the cultural legacy of New Orleans and its music and the people that created that music while at the same time we are driven and feel that it is imperative that we teach young people about that music. I mean it's the only way it's going to continue to live on.

MR: And thus the jazz camp.

JH: Well that's what, you know I felt that any young person that had an interest or a gift and wanted to learn jazz music in the city where it was created should have the opportunity to do so, whether they lived in New Orleans, whether they lived in Louisiana, in other states or in other countries. And if we are the birthplace of jazz, as we are, I think that it's incumbent upon us to, and if we're saying that we're trying to preserve this legacy, we must teach the young people about the people that created this music. And learning to play the music is very important. But you know the history of this music is American history. It's America's true and only art form. And so Phoebe and I are working together to try to get the story of the creation of jazz and these pioneers and heroes as part of what

MR: I couldn't agree more. It really has so much cultural legacy and it makes absolute sense that you learn it through the music and blues also.

JH: Right.

MR: Phoebe, I'm curious when you were oh let's say 18 or 19, did your girlfriends think that your interest in jazz music was a little out of the ordinary?

PJ: Of course. They all thought I was wacky. They couldn't believe it.

MR: At that time what was the normal teenager into music-wise?

PJ: Well you know you're going back a long time, you know, but I'm no baby. Like who was big in those days, Bing Crosby, who was the guy that did — oh a lot of romantic singers or people that you might get on Arthur Godfrey's show or something like that. Of course the one outstanding one is Bing Crosby as far as I was concerned. The Boswell Sisters were coming up, groups of that type.

MR: This is a little off the subject but how did the second World War affect the lives of musicians? Were you able to observe any of that?

PJ: Well the thing that I got out of the second World War was an awareness of what my heroes were doing that were here in America. Eubie Blake went to over 900 USO camps. Now I'm talking about a man whose mother and father were slaves and he never got a penny from the United States government but he had the calling and the need to go entertain his troops. Louis went, Duke went, I mean the greatest thing that these men had was their pride in their country.

MR: Did it surprise you that more of them did not turn out to be bitter with that kind of treatment?

PJ: Well again I've got to go back to Eubie. Because Eubie wrote a song during World War I, I don't know if you're aware about it, of the fact that the United States Army was segregated. And he went to Paris with James Reese Europe in 1919 or 1920 I believe. And he visited hospitals there and he watched a black soldier giving a blood transfusion to a white soldier. That's when he was tempted to write this song which he wrote, called "We Are Americans Too" which was so illustrious of what people like Eubie felt. And he never had any anger. He said, "Look if we're going to make it, we've got to do it with love for our fellow man."

MR: Well said. Do you recall in the early — was it at the club that you were working at , was it called —

PJ: Basin Street. It was named for Louis Armstrong. That's what attracted me to Jackie Harris. Not only was she living in the city where Louis was born but she helped us get the airport name for Louis Armstrong, she helped us get the statue in the park, and she has been our representative and part of our Louis Armstrong educational foundation and

camp is, as she's created, keepers of the flames. They're the kids that are going out there, now Nicholas Payton or Trombone Shorty, guys like that that come up from New Orleans, they were all inspired by Louis. You can't do anything in music that Louis hasn't played.

MR: As some of the people I've talked to complain that some of the young people think that jazz history started with John Coltrane you know.

JH: Well those kids don't live in New Orleans obviously. You know if you were to ask young people about, well some of them really know about Buddy Bolden, you know, and those guys in that era. But in New Orleans if you were to ask some that maybe hadn't been studying it they will tell you that Louis Armstrong was the first one. And that is the real unique thing about New Orleans is we know the history of the music.

MR: It's such a rich but sometimes confusing history racially with the Creole influence and all the nationalities there. Has that atmosphere, has a racial atmosphere let's say pre-Katrina at least, what was it like?

JH: Well you know it's obvious that there is racism in New Orleans but I mean it still exists. We can't say that racism existed in New Orleans and say that it was in the past because it's in the present now. But the unique thing about New Orleans, even in its racism, people in that town, black people and white people live right next door to each other. We eat at the same restaurants. We work in the same locations. But where the racism exists is part of classism and also in the competitive — it's very competitive there. And where it's obvious that this competition that has existed has really affected the abilities for people of color to earn a fair wage in that town. I mean Katrina showed us what that was. But I also have to say that in many cases I think that people have the wrong impression of people who have been affected by Katrina because Katrina had showed no racism. There are as many white people who are displaced and who are homeless as black people. If you go out to the Lakefront and to New Orleans East where a lot of affluent African-Americans and white people are, I mean they are, all of those homes are destroyed. And the unfortunate thing is there is no quick movement to really get that part of town rebuilt. I know that the city and the mayor is working, but those of us who are trying to get back home it seems that things are moving at a very snail pace. And let me say that if the people who are living in other states, the black people, are not helped to get back home the culture in New Orleans as we know it will not — it won't exist anymore. You see when you look at the second line in the brass band parade and social aid and pleasure clubs, that is a legacy that's in the heritage that was created by African-Americans and it's being perpetuated by African-Americans. We can bring musicians back home, which we need to bring them all home. But if there are no people in the streets to attend those

enough tourists to really participate in the second lines and tourists don't really know how to receive those people. So you know people talk about the new New Orleans, what is it going to be? If we as a group of native New Orleaneans and people who were born there and understand the quirks in our culture and teach our children and continue to do those things that make us what we call naturally New Orleans we are going to end up with something that's really not going to be authentic anymore.

MR: So you need a population — the music is not, it can't exist in a vacuum.

JH: No.

MR: You need, as you said, people to be in the second line so that those things can happen.

JH: See another thing too is, which is good, New Orleans musicians for the most part play all genres of music. Your traditional jazz artists play rhythm & blues, contemporary and avante garde artists play rhythm and blues, some play Gospel in the churches, some play classical music. And what's happened now is these bands are separated, they're divided. Now they're being called out to meet each other in different cities. But that is not going to last because these people don't get to practice together anymore, they're not eating the same red beans and rice and gumbo anymore, they're not attending the second lines together anymore. I mean there's a real disconnect there, and you know that connection is what has perpetuated that culture and that atmosphere and that spirit that makes New Orleans what it is. Take Mardi Gras. Mardi Gras is not going to be what it's been before. I mean we have black Mardi Gras clubs, there are white Mardi Gras clubs, black musicians perform at the balls at these clubs, they perform at the clubs that are hosted by black, you know by the African-American community. All that's going to be lost.

MR: Wow. It's a thick and deep subject for sure.

JH: It sure is. It is.

MR: Switching subjects a little bit, perhaps you can, Phoebe you can help me out with this, you know I've been looking through a seemingly endless supply of Louis Armstrong records and I often wondered how did he learn so many songs to be — how did he record so much music? Did you ever witness him learning?

PJ: Yes. I witnessed Louis learning. Louis' life was music. His dedication and his passion was performing. He lived to entertain people. It was effortless for him. It was like breathing. He told his wife Lucille, who he adored, you've got to understand, Mama, my horn comes first, and she understood and she never was jealous of his horn. But that was Louis. It was effortless for him to learn. But he'd go in a place, well that's how scat singing started, because he lost the music that was on the music stand but he didn't want to stop. He told the engineer to keep going and he just did his thing and he started scatting.

PJ: No. No. All you had to do was play it for Louis. No in fact you know when I first met Louis I worked at Decca Records. I know poor Jackie's heard the story ten times. But the first day I was there Milt Gabler and Sy Oliver, who was his musical director and Milt Gabler was the A&R man, who incidentally is Billy Crystal's uncle, darling man, wonderful, I loved him. They employed me as a secretary, sharpen pencils, file, you know all kind of that really coolie jobs. But they gave me the music and told me to bring it out to the recording studio. So I put the lead sheets on all the music stands and then I came to the music stands in front of the microphone which was Louis' microphone and I didn't have a trumpet part. So I went back in the office and I was absolutely beside myself. I started to cry. I thought well I'm losing my job. So everybody got hysterical laughing and when Louis came they told him, you see this girl? She lost your music. Well for years he never let me forget it. And of course what the funny part was that they told me that nobody writes a part for Louis. He just hears the song and he wings it.

MR: How did he decide what was going to be recorded?

PJ: Oh he didn't decide.

MR: He didn't decide? Who decided that for him?

PJ: Nobody. Guys would bring him stuff and he would — you know like Arvell Shaw used to tell the story of being out in Denver with Louis and people are screaming for "Hello Dolly." And Louis don't even know what they're talking about. So he has the band boy call me in New York asking me to send out some music for "Hello Dolly." He didn't even remember he recorded it. And it was a hit in England, not in America. So we sent the music out right away for the guys but Louis, you know, he picked things up like that.

MR: Did his musicians in the All-Stars, were they able to keep up with the pace? I mean I know they had to but, how did they feel about that?

PJ: In those days it was no pace, it was a way of life. I mean if a musician was usually married, had some kids and if he was — the guys that Louis worked with cared about their music as much as he did. So living on the road and being out 336 days a year was nothing to them. Look at Duke, he did the same thing with his band. I mean that was the lifestyle then. If the musician was passionate and wanted it, that was his life, that's what he did and he never thought about it any more than a doctor would think he's overworking because he is taking care of sick people. If you're passionate about what you're going to do, that's it.

MR: That's a good analogy. Can you remember the conversation that you had with him that led to the educational—

PJ: Oh well it was — I met Louis about — well you see I used to work for Louis part time. In other words Mr. Glaser was Louis Armstrong's manager and he would call me and I was

Pops wants you to come out and do this and this and this." So I'd take the day off and I'd do whatever Louis wanted because I just had a thing about Louis and he knew that he could count on me for anything. So he called me that day and I called him back I says, "Mr. Glaser says you need me." He said, "Well I want you to get the lawyer and I'd like him to" — Ellis his name was — "I'd like him to meet us for lunch, I've got to talk to you." I met him for lunch and he gives me a check for $40,000. In 1969 now, that $40,000 was a lot of money. And he said, "I want to give back to the world some of the goodness I got. I'd like to start a foundation." So I said, "Pops, Frank Sinatra doesn't have a foundation, The Beatles don't have a foundation, Elvis Presley don't have a foundation, what are you doing with a foundation?" He said, "Well I'm gonna have it and you're going to take care of it." So how lucky could I be? I met a lady like Jackie Harris, who started off our camp for us and she's got all these kids and of course through Jackie we have created jazz studies, which is something that has never been done in America. Columbia University, professor Bob O'Meally, has started a jazz studies program where young people do not have to learn an instrument, do not have to know a thing about jazz or music, but they're learning jazz studies just like they learn about America's history — American Revolution, the Civil War — and it's been going extremely well. Jackie and I visited Chicago. We got that started at the Columbia College of Chicago. Jackie has helped develop this at the University of New Orleans so we have jazz studies based on the formula that Bob O'Meally has done up at Columbia University in three colleges. And now Columbia College in Chicago is going to be doing, under the auspices of Jon Faddis, a great trumpet player and friend, going to be doing the Louis Armstrong Legacy which is based on what Wynton Marsalis created at the Jazz at Lincoln Center when he did Essentially Ellington and he gave music out to various high schools in the United States that have jazz bands so consequently they're following that pattern and we're going to be doing that in 2007 and it'll be the Louis Armstrong Legacy and we'll be starting with the Hot Five and the Hot Seven arrangements.

MR: That's fabulous. Jazz seems to be doing quite well in the universities and through efforts of people like yourselves. Do you have a sense of the music in the club scene and that kind of venue? What's the state of jazz in that realm?

JH: In New Orleans or in the United States?

MR: Well whatever you feel that you could address.

JH: I think that in major cities where we know that there is a great jazz legacy it's doing well. I mean if you look at Chicago, New York, probably Kansas and St. Louis, it's doing well. I think in other cities no, because if people are not supporting the music, if they're not playing it, if it's not part of the educational system in those cities, well there's obviously

because you know that's where the music was really created, that's where it was kind of nurtured. I think now in the United States we're moving in another direction. I think now we're educating young people at an earlier age about it. I also think though that I think school systems must incorporate jazz as part of its curriculum. And you know that doesn't exist a whole lot in the United States. Kids are taught classical music but not very much jazz. I think that's very important. And we don't have to worry about the music of the time because young people always gravitate to that and they do play that. And you know they don't have to know how to read music to play that. But I think that school systems must incorporate a curriculum for jazz music and as that happens then the night club scene will really grow and develop as well.

PJ: I've got to disagree with you on one thing, Jackie. You completely forgot festivals. Look how successful festivals have been.

JH: True, true.

PJ: And festivals attract an enormous amount of people. Jazz and Heritage Festival in New Orleans, 80,000 people a day. The JVC Festival in New York, the Fest of Chicago's has festivals. I mean all those things. I think they've replaced the night clubs. Instead of people going to a night club they're going to festivals.

JH: Well people are going to festivals which is good, and festivals are good family entertainment.

PJ: Right.

JH: But still I think the music was really nurtured in those clubs and there is, to me, there is nothing, you know—

PJ: Well you're right in that respect.

JH: than going to a nightclub to see a jazz artist.

PJ: Because at a festival, at a festival you have to be a star to be hired by a festival.

JH: That's true.

PJ: And in a nightclub you could just be an up and coming performer and they're going to give you a chance.

JH: That's right. And then they'll allow, in clubs, college students can come and sit in, you know, which is good and that's where they get their experience in performing in front of audiences.

PJ: True.

JH: And I don't want to see us lose that. You know? I would really like to see us continue and you're right because in a lot of cases a jazz artist can not get a gig at a festival if the producers do not see him as being able to attract a large number of, a large audience.

PJ: That have a name. Absolutely. You're absolutely right. And don't you think that the costs

JH: Really. Oh definitely. But you know when you look at, that's a hard risk. The night club business and the restaurant business is really, really a hard business. But I really am happy to see sometimes on Sundays you will see a jazz brunch in clubs and restaurants will, especially restaurants will hire musicians which is a good thing.

MR: Phoebe, as a fan of the music, was there time periods when new things were happening that you started to question like —

PJ: Oh my goodness yes. I mean I absolutely was horrified to think that people would use six microphones in Carnegie Hall and attach microphones to instruments, to electrify them. The distortion of sound disturbed me terribly. I couldn't bear it. And also to listen to the way people are playing music these days, the amount of volume, they take all the beauty out of the music. I know when Duke Ellington recorded at Carnegie Hall or Benny Goodman, they used one microphone. Pops only used one microphone. Carnegie Hall is such a wonderful hall of sound so the whole transition of like a Herbie Alpert — he's the first one, isn't he, that put the microphone in his trumpet — oh my God. I just couldn't bear that.

MR: Yeah it takes the balancing between the group, it takes it out of the musician's hands and gives it to a sound man.

JH: Well it's acoustic music.

PJ: It's not true sound, right?

JH: Right, right. I mean that's what it is. And I'll tell you, I'm like Phoebe, the microphones — she can't take the microphones but when I walk into a concert hall and I see a bunch of computers on the stage it's — you know my thought is well do they need all of that to create music? And so if they need that what do you say about the playing? You know? And people, we all hear it all at the same time. You know what I'm saying? So it's not — they're not going to be judged on the effectiveness of their electronic equipment.

PJ: You know what Pops had to say about that? He said he loves change because change represents progress. But when change takes something good and makes it worse, forget about it, he don't want to have nothing to do with it. That was good enough for me.

JH: That's a good one.

MR: I've often — people often describe Pops as a totally honest person. Is that a fair assessment of him?

PJ: I would say that you can't be emphatic enough about that. I have often thought having Satch the day that they called me to come to the office that Louis Armstrong passed, and I sat in a room where the head of every country, the head of every country, the presidents, the governors, the outpouring for this man's death was so outstanding that no matter how I measured him in his being vital to the world, I could never estimate how great it was.

stopped. Thank God it's never stopped. Every day of my life I get at least a minimum of two inquiries for the use of something of Louis Armstrong — his face, his voice, a tape — that's a minimum. And it comes from all over the world. But the interesting thing about this whole deal of people loving Louis is I try to analyze what is it. He wasn't handsome by standards of handsomness, like he wasn't a Harry Belafonte or a Sidney Poitier. He wasn't cultured, like Denzel Washington or one of those cats. But he had something that was magic that nobody else has, and that was pure honesty. He was honest and what you saw is what you got. He didn't care if you were president, if you were the King of England or who you were, he treated everybody the same way. He was honorable and honest and straightforward.

MR: When I listen to some of the Hot Five and Hot Seven, it sounds so new to me for that time. It's just unbelievable the exuberance that came out of his instrument. Indescribable.

PJ: Do you know that Wynton Marsalis is going to be doing three days of a salute to the Hot Five and the Hot Seven at Jazz at Lincoln Center in September of this year? And we succeeded in getting him to have his department market some of the tickets that can be sold for ten dollars to school children so that it isn't prohibitive for them to come into the Jazz at Lincoln Center, which is quite an expensive ticket.

MR: I think I was under a misconception about New Orleans and kind of what goes on there musically. And I don't think I'm alone. And that is it occurred to me when I put on a recent CD by Kidd Jordan and the music he was playing was like something John Coltrane had not thought of. And so I realized that I didn't really know what was coming out of that city.

JH: Well let me start by saying the creative music community is clearly not as large as straight ahead or traditional jazz is. But New Orleans jazz covers every facet of jazz music which we have heard. And artists, young artists, as they develop for the most part, they really go through those different phases of jazz — playing jazz music until they reach the one that they are most comfortable with and the one that they decide that they want to make a career and play. But then too if you look at Nicholas Payton, so Nicholas's father, Walter Payton, you could say he's a traditional jazz artist but he's also a blues artist or he's also a rhythm & blues artist. So Nicholas plays trad, he plays contemporary, but then also he has done electronic. Then look at Branford, he's done the same thing. Donald Harrison Jr. now has a smooth jazz CD which he gave me a couple of copies of it last week so he says to me look, I'm going to give you this, you probably don't like it but I know this — I know you don't like this but you know I'm doing this now too. I mean and Donald is the son of a Mardi Gras Indian chief, Donald Harrison Sr., and Donald plays Mardi Gras music as well. I mean Aaron Neville did a jazz CD a year

PJ: Look at Elvis Costello, what he's doing with this.

JH: Yeah. With Allen Toussaint. You know you just can't, on any given day it's kind of like football, on any given day you can't imagine what or where you may see a New Orleanean playing. Troy "Trombone" Andrews' roots are in traditional jazz music. I mean he was playing the trombone on the streets of New Orleans in brass bands when he was eight years old, maybe even five, the trumpet was taller than he was. He goes out with Lenny Kravitz now.

MR: With Lenny Kravitz?

JH: Yes, yeah.

MR: I'll be darned.

PJ: And how about Harry Connick Jr.? Look at how colorful his career's been.

JH: Exactly. You just, you can't tell. And then even Donald as he gave me this smooth jazz album, we talked about how he played because Kidd was his teacher, how for a period of time he only wanted to play avante garde. You know, now people don't know that and even the music that he records now you would have to dig way back to find an avante garde album of Donald Harrison if it really exists, and I didn't know he had played avante garde but he did. He says, "Oh for a minute I was mad too when I played that."

MR: He was mad too?

JH: No, no, no, not mad, well you see —

PJ: Angry?

JH: Well yes, angry. But you see and we talked about, we had a great conversation because we talked about the Coltrane years. And the Miles years. And Kidd. And the artists of that time. I mean this is during the civil rights movement in the sixties. And so these artists were expressing their feeling of frustration and also they were actually expressing the feelings of the African-American community in America at that time and they were taking us from one part of our history and how we were living to the next part of history. And so that is what that music was all about. And you know different groups were formed, you know, out of this. And so, and then that art of that genre of music, I attended the Vision Music Festival, and then I was thinking there's not a whole lot of young musicians playing that music. And so now I think and I says I hope this is not a dying art.

MR: I've seen a similar thing with the jazz parties across the country that these promoters, different from festivals, you know they do these jazz parties where people come and they stay for the weekends and they listen to what you would I guess call classic or mainstream jazz. The two things I've noticed is that first of all the audience is all elderly people, they're almost all white, and the musicians are almost all white. And I'm wondering where are the young or middle-aged black musicians to play that music? I'm

JH: Well I know but if you look in New York and New Orleans, Chicago, again we go back to those mainstream cities where the music is being perpetuated, kids are learning the music in schools, and so young people are playing that. When you go to the International Association of Jazz Educators now and you're right in a sense because when you look at the ratio of African-Americans versus white kids you see more white kids playing that. But it's the black universities for the most part are not supporting that. So here the music went, so it started in the nightclubs, right? Then it kind of went to the college campuses. So now the college campuses, the HBCU's, aren't doing anything with the schools, but the white schools are playing it. I mean when you look at New Orleans, the University of New Orleans has an excellent jazz education program. Even the Louis Armstrong Educational Foundation now funds a master's program in jazz studies which is a full ride for seven young college students and they also do outreach in New Orleans Public Schools in jazz education. But Xavier University, which is a New Orleans university, doesn't have a jazz program. The University of — SUNO — Southern University of New Orleans, where Kidd headed the jazz studies program, just discontinued it. Kidd just retired. Dillard University had an artist in residence there and did a little something in jazz education but there's no real jazz curriculum there.

PJ: Is that since Katrina?

JH: No. That was before Katrina. But Tulane University has one and so does Loyola. They are two white universities.

MR: And Tulane has the wonderful archive also.

JH: Yeah. Um hum. It does. The Hogan Jazz Archive.

MR: Yeah. Well it's interesting. Sometimes I think the things that drive universities to do certain things are not necessarily for the sake of the music or whatever. They come from other —

JH: Right. Endowments.

MR: Endowments, yes, like who are we trying to keep happy here so to speak. Or what are the other people doing?

JH: Right. But you know what that means is the African-American community, especially those fortunate people in the community, they've got to step up.

MR: Well Phoebe, you've had quite a list of friends and compatriots. And I'm just wondering if you want to share any thoughts about some of them. I just finished reading a book about Peggy Lee and she seemed to be a person who was never quite happy with what she was accomplishing in music, or am I misreading that?

PJ: Well of course I helped Peter Richmond with that book because he knew that I worked with Peggy. And her daughter said that I knew Peggy better than she knew her own

in order to make a book sensational or a little more commercial they go into extremes. For example the documentary that they did on Ella Fitzgerald to show her as a very unhappy woman. Ella was not an unhappy woman. And Peggy Lee, she was a human being so there were times in her life where she was depressed or she was lonely, she had a bad romance or something. But basically she was a very, very spiritual lady. She was very active in science of the mind and she was practitioner of her church and her spirit and her Bible reading used to enhance her enormously. So I didn't agree with the image that Peter was trying to convey to the readers, but I felt that he did a good job. I mean I'm not going to criticize his book, it's just that I didn't — it's like anything else, we all see some side of a human being in our own evaluation of them. You know it doesn't necessarily mean that we're right. I choose to see the positiveness of Peggy as a performer or Ella as an artist or any one of these people because I know what it took out of them to get up on a stage and pour their heart out. Because performances were not just something that was mechanical. This was something they lived. I mean when Ella would come off wringing wet like Louis, she put everything into it. Sarah. Peggy would treat every lyric like it was a soliloquy of a Shakespearean play. She created her audience, gave them a mood, a feeling, just like Louis did. She was spiritual. That was what Louis had. She was very spiritual. In fact every one of the — look at Duke, how spiritual he got. And Sarah started out in the church. Ella Fitzgerald was always involved with the church. So most of the artists of the generation that I was raised in were very close to God. And then they came, first of all before Peggy Lee would get on the stage she would do her prayers backstage before she put her foot out. Ella Fitzgerald would say, look up at the heaven, I don't know what she said, but one day when I asked her she said, "Well I could go out there and open up my mouth and nothing's gonna come out. I want to make sure I've got it covered." That answer your question? I took the long way around.

MR: No, the spirit of these individuals comes across in their performance for sure, and was Duke Ellington, I never had the pleasure of meeting him. Was he as charming as everyone makes him to be?

PJ: Nobody makes him out to be anything that he wasn't. He had exquisite manners and style. He was absolutely charming. He was the essence of refinement whether he had his dinner or he would talk to a waiter or a busboy, whatever it was he did he did it like an elegant gentleman. He had exquisite vocabulary, expressed himself divinely and nobody really knew Duke Ellington because there were about ten Duke Ellingtons. I never knew which one he was going to bring into work.

MR: Well name a few of the Duke Ellingtons.

PJ: Well let's say Duke Ellington was very complex in the sense that he could adjust himself

be 80 years old, I worked at the Rainbow Room and Duke Ellington was the artist that was performing with his orchestra. And I said to Mercer, who was part of his band and was very involved in his father's career, that was Duke's only son, "Merce, I got a lady that's having a birthday party, 80 years, when the band breaks does their break let them all come for champagne and cake, it would make her very happy. She'll be very excited." And I invited everybody and they all came. And suddenly, who do I see come walking down the steps but Duke Ellington. And I said, "Edward, what are you doing here?" He says, "Well you invited everybody but me." I said, "Well I didn't think you'd have any interest in this girl, she's going to be 80 years old." He loved women but not 80 years old. He sat and talked to Mrs. Rice for an hour for his entire break. And then for years afterwards she was sending him mass cards, and he would send her flowers. That was one Ellington that amazed me. I couldn't believe, what could he have in common with an 80-year-old woman. By the same token you could go into a restaurant with Duke and he had a French poodle that Joe Glaser gave him and he loved Davy and he'd have permission to go into the Hickory House with Davy and Davy would sit right next to Edward on the side of his seat and never move. And if Ellington fed him he'd feed him with his hand and the dog was very well behaved. He got into a conversation with the bus boy 'cause the bus boy's father raised poodles. And for the rest of the night he didn't talk to me. Then another time he said to me, "Don't go home now, wait around I'll take you for breakfast." Okay, that was exciting, to go to breakfast with Duke. And he used to love to go to a restaurant called Reuben's on 58th Street and Fifth Avenue. He had a charge account there. We come down stairs at Rockefeller Center, it's two o'clock in the morning, and we get a cab. We go from 51st Street over to 58th Street, pull up in front of the restaurant and Duke says, "Pay him." I paid the cab. We get into the restaurant I said to him, "Edward, why do you have pockets?" He said, "I like to keep my hands in 'em." He never walked around with money. He didn't like to handle money it's very dirty. I mean he had so many different — and then he couldn't come in his room, wear anything green, because he was wearing a green tie when he got the news that his mother died. So he was so many, he was so — and then how he treated his sister. His sister Ruth he treated like she was Shirley Temple or Cinderella wrapped all in one. Ruthie was, she'd send mink coats to the club and I'd call Mr. Ellington and I'd say "I have a man who wants $3,400" or something, Ruth's fur coat. He'd say, "Well give it to the gentleman." You know I mean it was part of his salary I mean I could give it to him but I wasn't going to do it unless he said so. I mean he would just do outlandish things. He was absolutely off the wall but delightful.

MR: Why were his sidemen so mostly loyal to him?

PJ: Because he was loyal to them. What orchestra do you know in the entire world, what orchestra leader could have his orchestra working 350 days of the year and charter a train for his orchestra because he doesn't want them to be embarrassed by being ostracized because of their color and not be able to stay at a hotel or not able to go to a restaurant. So he rents two luxurious trains and he's got his own chef and his own kitchen and everyplace they pull in, they go to a city, they stop there, they dis — whatever they call it — unlatch the train, the cars, and stop at the railroad yard and that's where the guys stayed. And they just I mean let's face it — and also Ellington used to write pieces for them. I mean if he wrote a thing that required a lot of wonderful trumpet parts it was just for Cootie Williams. If he did something for saxophone he'd write just for Johnny Hodges or Harry Carney. I mean he wrote for the guys that played with his band because he knew what they could do. They inspired him. And I guess they just loved it.

MR: It was a good gig.

JH: Yes it was. A great gig.

MR: Gee. I was interested to see you also have some involvement with the Society of Singers where our good friend Joe Williams received a —

PJ: Yes he did, an honor one year. Well the Society of Singers started because Ella Fitzgerald and Frank Sinatra used to be approached by singers in need. Like Louis Armstrong and Duke and many of them were approached by musicians in need. And they decided it would be a wonderful thing if they could get something going where a singer could, with some dignity, could approach an organization and get some help. So a man by the name of Bud Granoff, who used to work for Frank Sinatra, was a very successful publisher married to a lady by the name of Kitty Kallen. And they got together with Ella and Frank to form the Society of Singers in Hollywood. Of course after a couple of months and some internal problems they retired from it but not until Buddy Granoff got all the singers that were interested, like Bing Crosby, Helen O'Connell, Tony Bennett, Peggy Lee, all to give a duty — no wait a minute, that's not the word I want — doing royalty-free permission to release their hit record and he put it on one LP and all the proceeds was going to the Society of Singers. And then they decided on the gala, of course they got Merv Griffin, you know Merv Griffin used to be a band singer. So they got Merv Griffin to give them the ballroom of the Beverly Hilton Hotel in Los Angeles where they did a fundraiser and instead of giving out a Tony or an Oscar they gave out an Ella. And I, having worked for Ella and Peggy and all these people, I volunteered to be part of that. So I still — I'm not as active as I was but I still proceed to do whatever I can.

MR: Yeah. Well it sounds like your calendar is always full to me. When I look at the things that both of you are doing.

PJ: I'll tell you what Pops used to say, you know, he said he was a work in progress. He said I'm not finished yet. I don't know what's going to happen when I'm finished. So I decided I like that. I'm a work in progress. And I manage to surround myself with people I can learn from like Ms. Harris.

MR: Do you think Louis Armstrong had a sense of how loved he was?

PJ: No, no. Not at all. In fact it was my habit in working in a club, and I told you some of the people we had, Duke, Ella, Sarah, Basie, Oscar Peterson, Louis. After opening I would read the papers and I'd go in the dressing room and I'd read them something or I'd leave it in the dressing room. I said to Pops, "Did you see the review?" He said, "I don't read that stuff." I said, "Louis, aren't you — I don't believe you, it was just so exciting," whatever. He said, "Look, I'm not interested. When a trumpet player will write something about me I'll read it. He said those guys, I don't want nothing. He used to be very angry when he'd read reviews, for example, around the time that Louis was working at this particular moment, Ella Fitzgerald was loused up by somebody at the *Evening Journal*. It seemed that she was invited to sing at a benefit in Madison Square Garden and without her knowledge her manager decided that she wasn't going to do it. He just didn't want to let her go to Madison Square Garden and sing for the Boys of Italy or whatever it was, so this writer, this columnist who was involved with the Boys Town of Italy gave Ella's show a write-up of four columns, twelve paragraphs, about Ray Bryant, who was the piano player that opened for Ella, and gave Ella one paragraph at the end of the article saying, and the usual Ella Fitzgerald charm was spread around the rest of the night or something. And that was it. And boy when we called it to Pop's attention he was so mad, he just didn't want to read any papers. He really just felt it was terrible. So I don't think he ever dreamed — first of all I was very close to it and when he died and things happened like they did and they're still happening I become flabbergasted. It's beyond my imagination that — the love. When I look at a tape of Edward R. Murrow's show that he did in 1957 of Louis Armstrong in Ghana and they estimate approximately 250,000 people pouring out from all over, they stopped a war to come and hear Louis, and he came back and I said to him, "Pops, what happened when you went to Africa? You don't speak Swahili and you don't speak Mambazo. How did you communicate?" He said, "I picked up my horn and I blew." He said, "'cause a note is a note in any language."

MR: That's great. When you get home, what's on your CD player?

JH: Now which home are you talking about? No I'm just teasing. Right now in my CD player is Stephanie and Marlon Jordan's CD, a very good one. Do you have it?

MR: I don't have it.

PJ: Do you want to know what's on my CD?

PJ: In 1937 Louis Armstrong was the first man of color to have a coast to coast radio show. A man by the name of Rudy Vallee was an ardent fan of Louis Armstrong's and when his boss the Fleishman's Yeast Hour, the president of the Fleishman Company asked him for a replacement, Rudy Vallee said I want Louis Armstrong to replace me for two months. And of course they wouldn't hear of it. So he said, "Well I will break my contact or I want to hire Louis and I want to own the shows." Those radio shows were done and they were all on matrix, those enormous metal discs. I discovered them in the house when I was clearing the house out when Mrs. Armstrong passed because Louis Armstrong and Lucille both left me in charge of the legacy and heritage. And I was taking care of all the papers and getting things ready for the college and giving some things to his sister, or whatever I was going to do I found these. And I gave them to a man in Washington because I had no equipment to play them, I didn't know what it was. So they finally, it's been I'd say 15 years they were working on this. We finally, they send me a CD and it's in my house for me to listen to when I come back, of these radio shows.

MR: Oh wow.

PJ: 1937. Isn't that going to be something.

JH: Oh yeah.

MR: It must have been a pretty emotional experience to be going through the things in his home.

PJ: Oh my God yes. Oh his wife was, you could have performed surgery in her kitchen. This woman was a clean freak like you don't believe. She had Louis' clothes, everything, their house was, well you've just got to go to see their house, you're just not going to believe it. 'Cause Lucille was, see Lucille wanted to move next to Jackie Robinson up in Connecticut. And they could well afford it. But Pops said, "Look, you wanna go move there, give me the address I'll send you a check but I'm staying right here. I like my neighbors and I like my house." So she made the house into something very, very graciously beautiful and with just every kind of a convenience you could think of. And she was so creative, and like Louis, she was a work in progress. If she did something in her kitchen she made sure it was the latest thing. I never saw anybody that had a revolving spice shelf in the grocery closet, did you?

JH: No.

PJ: Well Lucille Armstrong did. She put her spices on and she wanted to reach in the back so she said to the man why can't you put a lazy Susan on my shelf so it could rotate. She bought an electric Mixmaster. She didn't want to worry about plugging into the wall, put the plug right in the counter so I'll take the Mixmaster canister and put it right on the counter and it'll be plugged in. And that's what she got. And so she was unbelievable.

like jewels. But don't forget, they also asked me to be in charge of the legacy and heritage and this, now we have the house opened as a museum. And people come from all over the world in fact we get requests because we have a walkie-talkie thing that you can rent when you go into the house, we get requests in four different languages because there's so many people from Italy, and Germany, and Spain. And we have a need for other languages.

MR: We're lucky that he was so into writing letters and recording things. When I visited the Archive and Michael —

PJ: Michael Cogswell.

MR: He showed me—

PJ: Wonderful, wonderful man.

MR: The tape boxes that he would—

PJ: The collage that Louis —

MR: When did he have time to do that if he was working, in between shows?

PJ: You know one of the things that I had to dispose of in the house must have been 14 pairs of scissors, you know little scissors that you'd cut paper dolls stuff. 'Cause wherever Louis went he'd get a new pair of scissors or his scissors wasn't sharp enough or something. So he'd come home with two scissors. And Lucille would have a drawer with all the scissors that he had. But he loved, in fact one time he said to her this room is mine, right, the den? He did the collage all over the ceiling. When I came in there I couldn't believe it. I said, "You've got to be kidding, what do people have to lay down and look up at your ceiling?"

MR: It's his own Sistine Chapel.

JH: Yes. Isn't that something? Wonderful.

PJ: But you know his collages were so revealing. One of his collages he has a huge picture of himself and in that picture of himself he's got pictures of Malcolm X, Duke Ellington, all in his brain, all the men that he admired. Did you ever see that collage?

MR: No.

PJ: Dynamite. I mean Louis was so intelligent. He was so well read. You know when I saw a book on Hitler on Louis's shelf I said to him, "Pops, how the hell do you read about this monster?" He said, "Look, you've got to know why you're hating somebody." He just felt if they're going to put it in a library and people are going to talk about it you have to learn it. You have to learn all this. And he had it. That's the last present I gave him was a book on birds and foliage because Lucille fixed the garden and she wanted him to recuperate out in the garden and he loved to learn about plants and different things that she had back there. He was very curious about life around him. He was an amazing

MR: Well this has really been fascinating just to wrap up, is there anything that you'd like to share with me about, either one of you, about the projects you're working on? I know you're on a lot of them.

JH: Well I just want to say, not a project that I'm working on but a project I did work on I think. I think having named the New Orleans International Airport for Louis Armstrong was a really significant thing not just for New Orleans but for the United States. I can't think of any artist that was most deserving of that and it's the first airport to be named for a jazz artist. I think that what that has done, although people know Louis Armstrong, people know New Orleans, but I think people that don't know anything about jazz music when they travel to New Orleans and this airport is named for Louis Armstrong I think that's very important, it's important for the children too to see that.

MR: I can tell you've made a big impression on my wife and myself when we went there. It was over a year ago but—

PJ: Well we have Marc Morial to thank as well as Jackie Harris.

MR: But you know you're arriving there and you're leaving there and so those are the impressions you get when you arrive and when you leave so that's terrific.

PJ: Well I'd like to say that I want to thank you enormously for the opportunity you've given us because we feel that this is a message that many generations we hope will enjoy and take something from and be inspired by, and we thank you so much for giving us the opportunity and I thank you Jackie for joining.

JH: Well I enjoyed sitting with you as well. Thank you very much.

MR: Well it's got to be something about the music because the people I've met that are associated with jazz have just been the classiest group, so on that note—

PJ: That's for sure. You're right. Well we know that because we have music therapy in the hospital named for Louis and we know what it's done. Because Louis had a nephew who had a problem and he put him in a mental institution after nobody in the family could take care of him anymore. And the boy was, well he was a man of 32 and he was not acting properly and when Louis came to visit him he knew one thing, that Clarence didn't have any music where he was, where he had always been in an atmosphere of music. So he insisted that this facility at least allow him to send some music that Clarence could enjoy because it wasn't only Louis' music that he sent. He sent classical music as well and religious music. And the institution felt that this was wonderful for their patients. So consequently when he died Beth Israel Hospital was a hospital that he loved very much and was a patient at, we succeeded in having them do the Louis and Lucille Armstrong Music Therapy Program which is in existence for twelve years, and it's been expanding and is now going to take care of musicians as well as people that just happen to be

MR: That's terrific. Well thanks to both of you for the important work you do. And it's really uplifting to know that there's support like this going on.

JH: And thank you, and it's uplifting to know that you're doing what you're doing as well because if we don't get this history and don't record it and get the history from the people like Phoebe that lived it, we have none.

MR: All right.

PJ: Because there are no books about it yet. We didn't write one.

MR: Well I think we should.

JH: Well Monk can write the book. He'll write it.

MR: All right. Thank you very much.

PJ: Thank you, thank you Tim. Thank you very much.